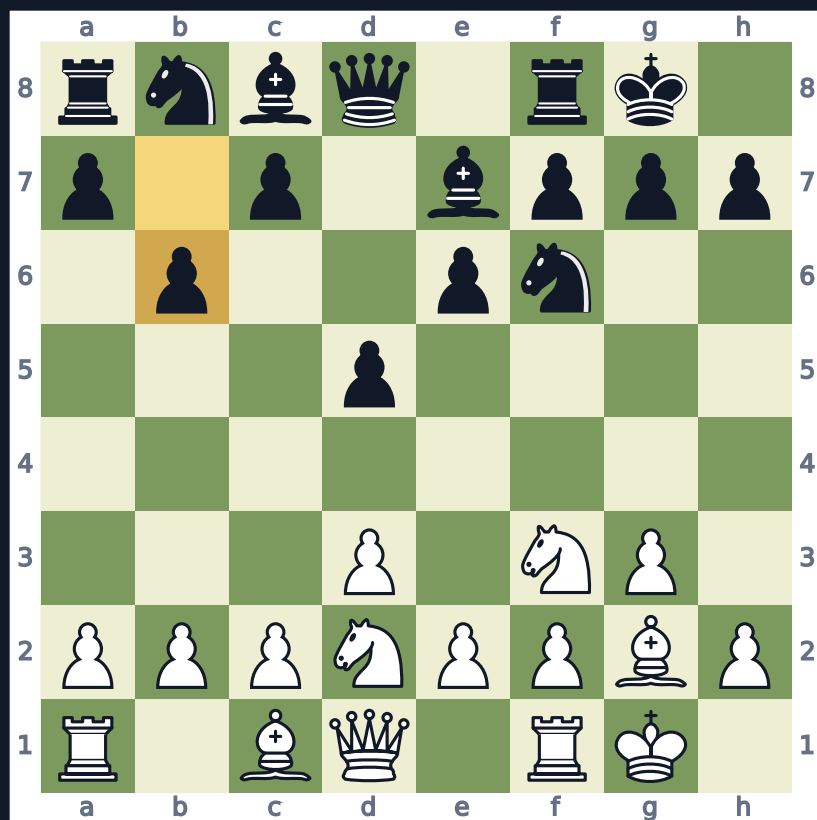


12

The KIA against ...e6 and ...b6

Queenside fianchetto pressure, the e4 target, and central choices against a flexible black setup.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will meet ...b6 systems without allowing the b7 bishop to dominate e4 or drifting into a centerless position.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 067 | PAGE 4

Decode: Black fianchettoes on b7*Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.*

LESSON 068 | PAGE 8

Play: Black fianchettoes on b7*Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.*

LESSON 069 | PAGE 12

Decode: The ...c5 central challenge*Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.*

LESSON 070 | PAGE 16

Play: The ...c5 central challenge*Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.*

LESSON 071 | PAGE 20

Decode: White's c3 restraint*A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.*

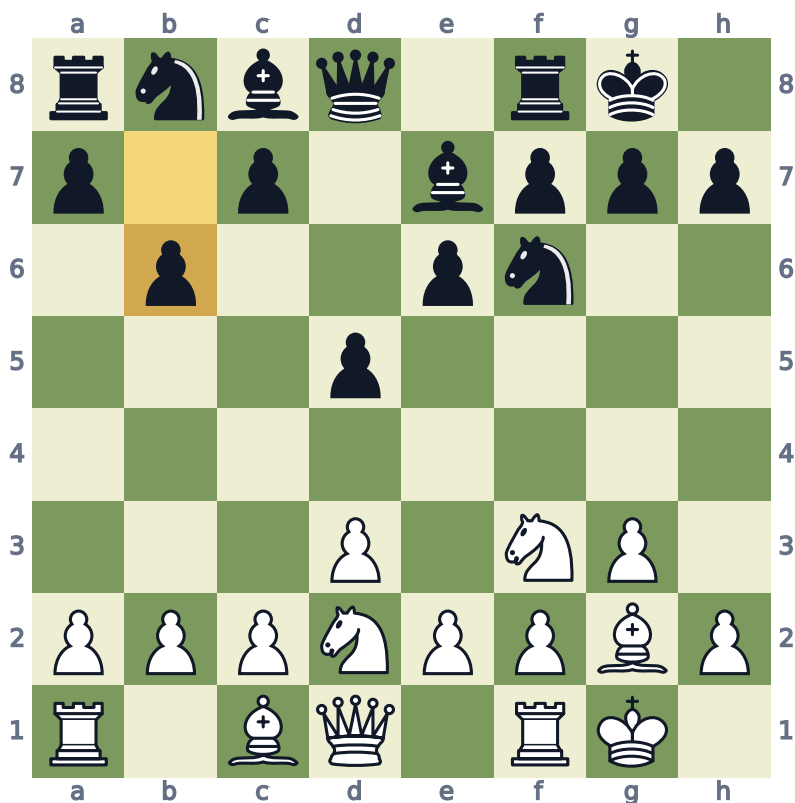
LESSON 072 | PAGE 24

Play: White's c3 restraint*A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will meet ...b6 systems without allowing the b7 bishop to dominate e4 or drifting into a centerless position.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Black fianchettoes on b7



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The b7 bishop pressures e4 and the long diagonal, making White's center both a space asset and a tactical responsibility.

DECISION RULE

How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black attacks e4 with pieces, prepares ...dxe4 or ...c5, and uses the flexible center to avoid a fixed kingside target.

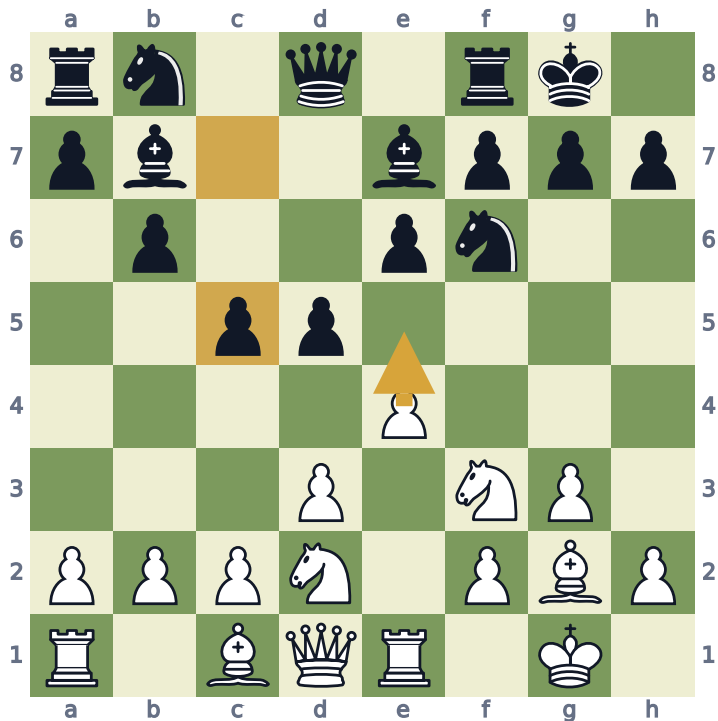
WHITE'S PLAN

White reinforces e4 economically, chooses e5 only when it gains time, and considers c3 or Qe2 to support the center.

MEMORY RULE | Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The b7 bishop pressures e4 and the long diagonal, making White's center both a space asset and a tactical responsibility.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black attacks e4 with pieces, prepares ...dxe4 or ...c5, and uses the flexible center to avoid a fixed kingside target.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White reinforces e4 economically, chooses e5 only when it gains time, and considers c3 or Qe2 to support the center.

FAILURE MODE

Starting a kingside maneuver while e4 can be won by a simple central exchange.

DECISION TEST

Ask: How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

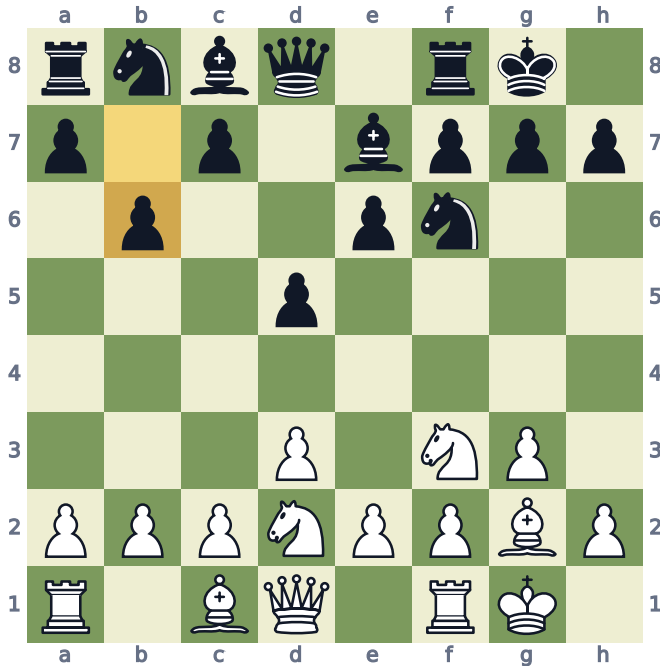
RULE | Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The b7 bishop pressures e4 and the long diagonal, making White's center both a space asset and a tactical responsibility.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed? White's attacking or positional plan is: White reinforces e4 economically, chooses e5 only when it gains time, and considers c3 or Qe2 to support the center. The line fails as a template when: Starting a kingside maneuver while e4 can be won by a simple central exchange.

STORE THIS | Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

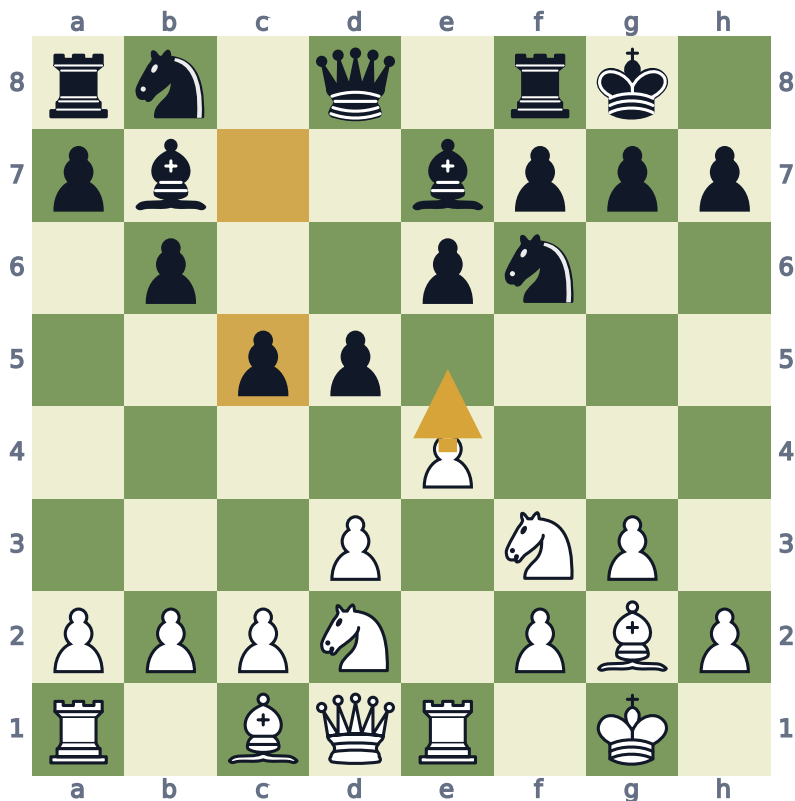
1. The b7 bishop pressures e4 and the long diagonal, making White's center both a space asset and a tactical responsibility. 2. Black attacks e4 with pieces, prepares ...dxe4 or ...c5, and uses the flexible center to avoid a fixed kingside target. 3. White reinforces e4 economically, chooses e5 only when it gains time, and considers c3 or Qe2 to support the center. 4. How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed? 5. Starting a kingside maneuver while e4 can be won by a simple central exchange.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Black fianchettoes on b7



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The b7 bishop pressures e4 and the long diagonal, making White's center both a space asset and a tactical responsibility.

DECISION RULE

How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black attacks e4 with pieces, prepares ...dxe4 or ...c5, and uses the flexible center to avoid a fixed kingside target.

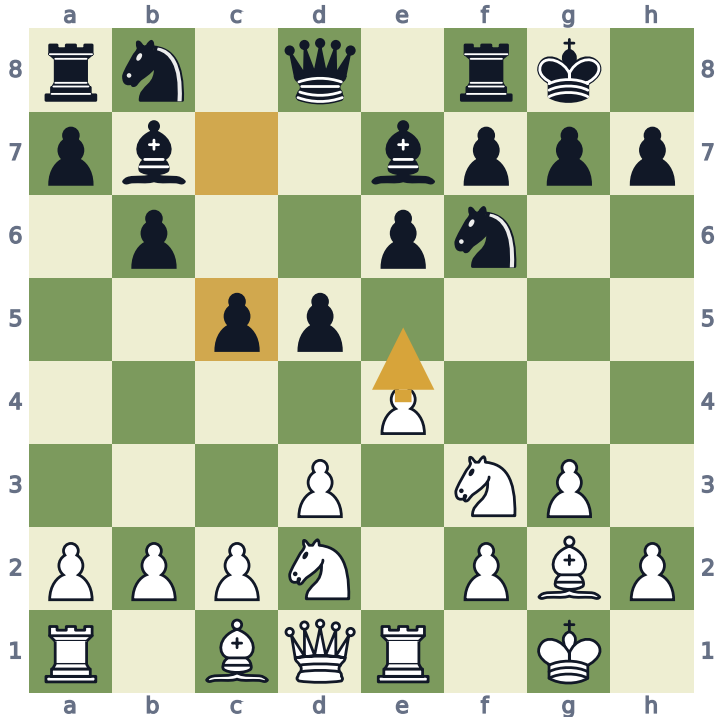
WHITE'S PLAN

White reinforces e4 economically, chooses e5 only when it gains time, and considers c3 or Qe2 to support the center.

MEMORY RULE | Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The b7 bishop pressures e4 and the long diagonal, making White's center both a space asset and a tactical responsibility.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black attacks e4 with pieces, prepares ...dxe4 or ...c5, and uses the flexible center to avoid a fixed kingside target.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White reinforces e4 economically, chooses e5 only when it gains time, and considers c3 or Qe2 to support the center.

FAILURE MODE

Starting a kingside maneuver while e4 can be won by a simple central exchange.

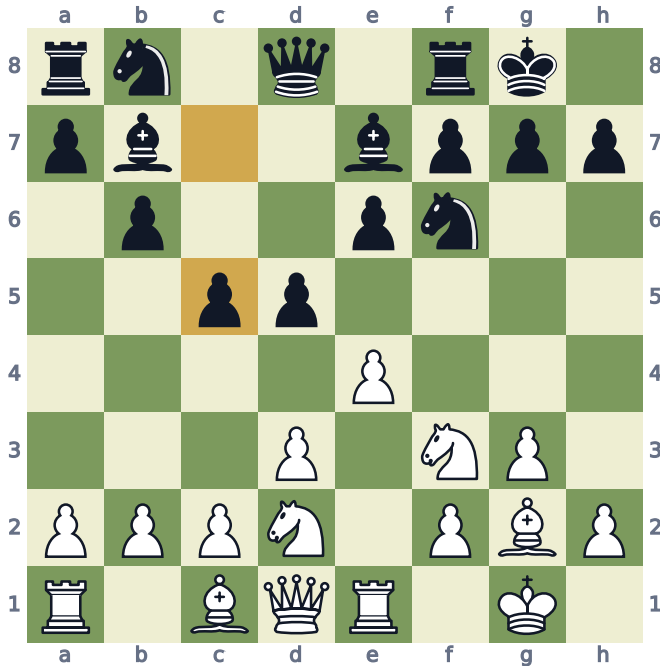
DECISION TEST

Ask: How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

Move-by-move meaning

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5



- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- c5: White attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.

The b7 bishop pressures e4 and the long diagonal, making White's center both a space asset and a tactical responsibility.

How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed? White's attacking or positional plan is: White reinforces e4 economically, chooses e5 only when it gains time, and considers c3 or Qe2 to support the center. The line fails as a template when: Starting a kingside maneuver while e4 can be won by a simple central exchange.

STORE THIS | Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

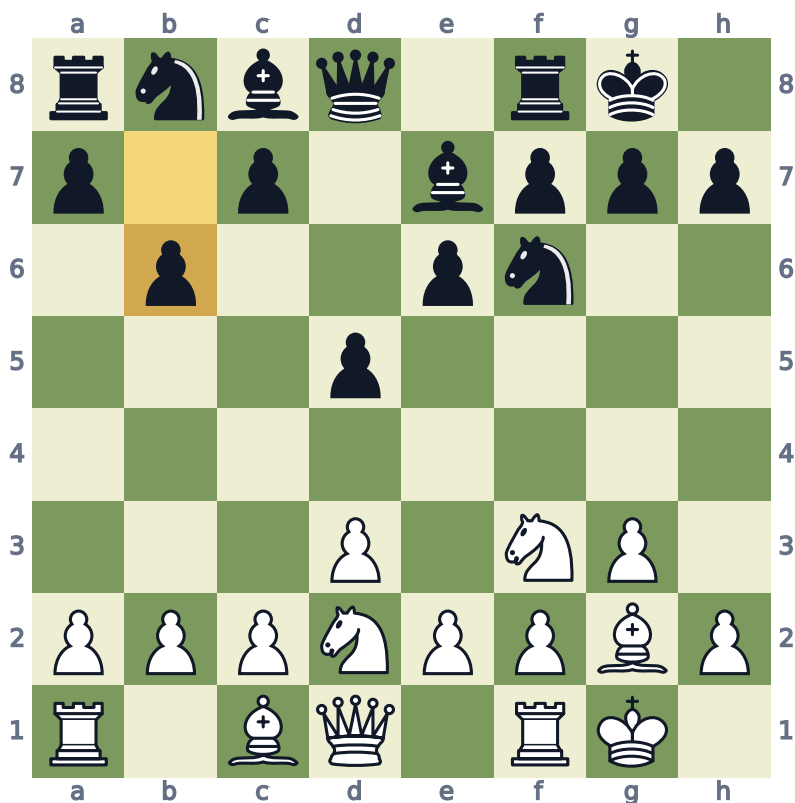
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The ...c5 central challenge



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When ...c5 joins ...Bb7, Black attacks d4 and e4 from two directions; White's e5 gains space but must survive undermining pressure.

DECISION RULE

Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares ...Nc6, ...Qc7, and ...f6 or ...d4 while the b7 bishop supports central contact.

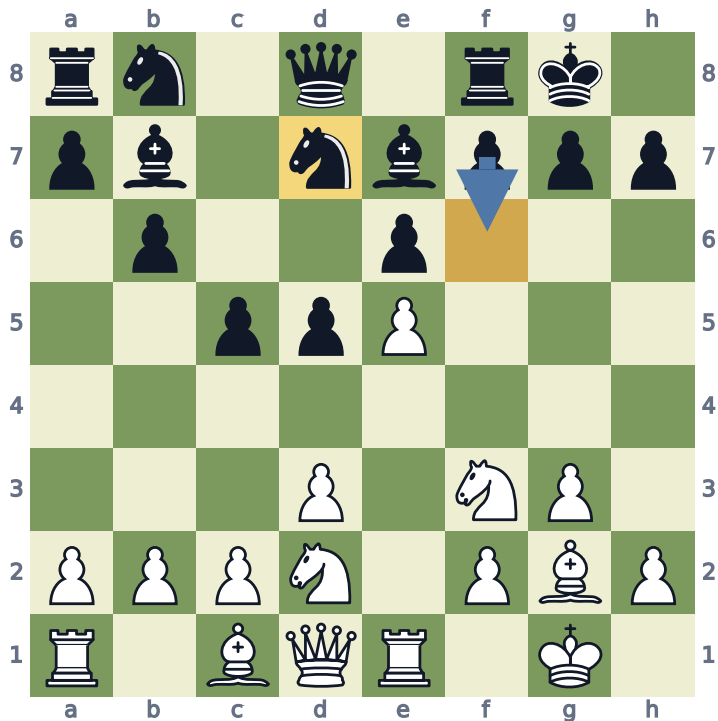
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the knight retreat tempo to improve the attack and watches whether c3 is needed to restrain ...d4.

MEMORY RULE | Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

When ...c5 joins ...Bb7, Black attacks d4 and e4 from two directions; White's e5 gains space but must survive undermining pressure.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares ...Nc6, ...Qc7, and ...f6 or ...d4 while the b7 bishop supports central contact.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses the knight retreat tempo to improve the attack and watches whether c3 is needed to restrain ...d4.

FAILURE MODE

Assuming the bishop is dead after e5 while Black has a direct pawn break to release it.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

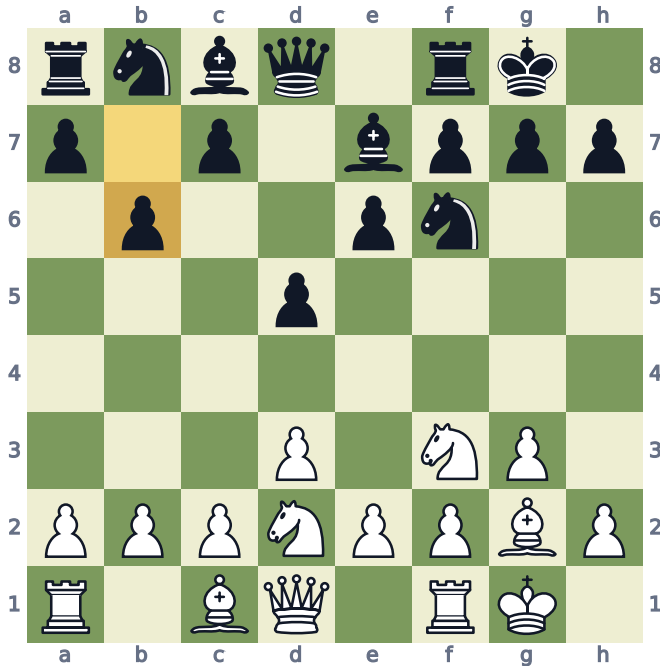
RULE | Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. e5 Nfd7



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When ...c5 joins ...Bb7, Black attacks d4 and e4 from two directions; White's e5 gains space but must survive undermining pressure.

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Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses the knight retreat tempo to improve the attack and watches whether c3 is needed to restrain ...d4. The line fails as a template when: Assuming the bishop is dead after e5 while Black has a direct pawn break to release it.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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ANSWER KEY

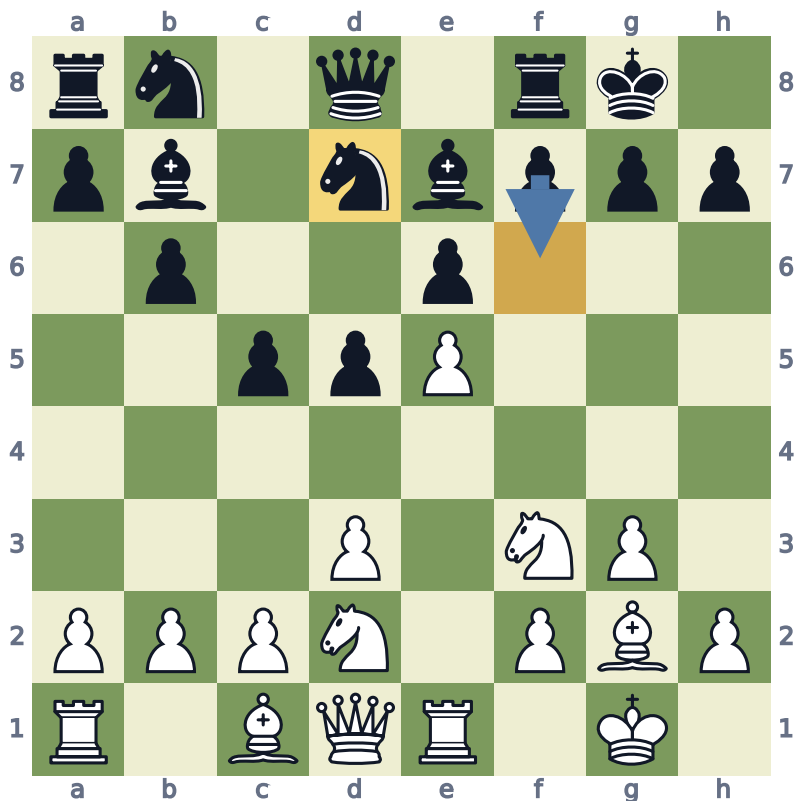
1. When ...c5 joins ...Bb7, Black attacks d4 and e4 from two directions; White's e5 gains space but must survive undermining pressure. 2. Black prepares ...Nc6, ...Qc7, and ...f6 or ...d4 while the b7 bishop supports central contact. 3. White uses the knight retreat tempo to improve the attack and watches whether c3 is needed to restrain ...d4. 4. Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4? 5. Assuming the bishop is dead after e5 while Black has a direct pawn break to release it.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The ...c5 central challenge



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When ...c5 joins ...Bb7, Black attacks d4 and e4 from two directions; White's e5 gains space but must survive undermining pressure.

DECISION RULE

Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares ...Nc6, ...Qc7, and ...f6 or ...d4 while the b7 bishop supports central contact.

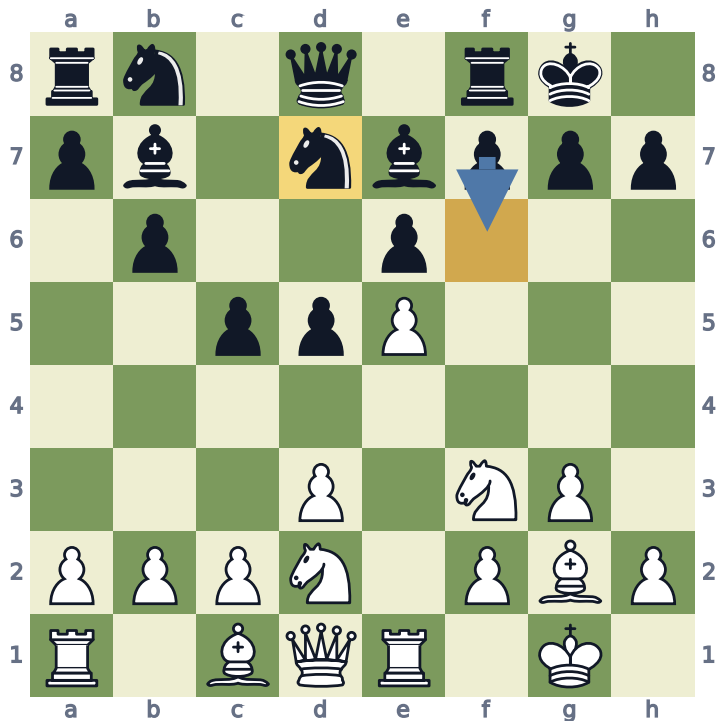
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the knight retreat tempo to improve the attack and watches whether c3 is needed to restrain ...d4.

MEMORY RULE | Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

When ...c5 joins ...Bb7, Black attacks d4 and e4 from two directions; White's e5 gains space but must survive undermining pressure.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares ...Nc6, ...Qc7, and ...f6 or ...d4 while the b7 bishop supports central contact.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses the knight retreat tempo to improve the attack and watches whether c3 is needed to restrain ...d4.

FAILURE MODE

Assuming the bishop is dead after e5 while Black has a direct pawn break to release it.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

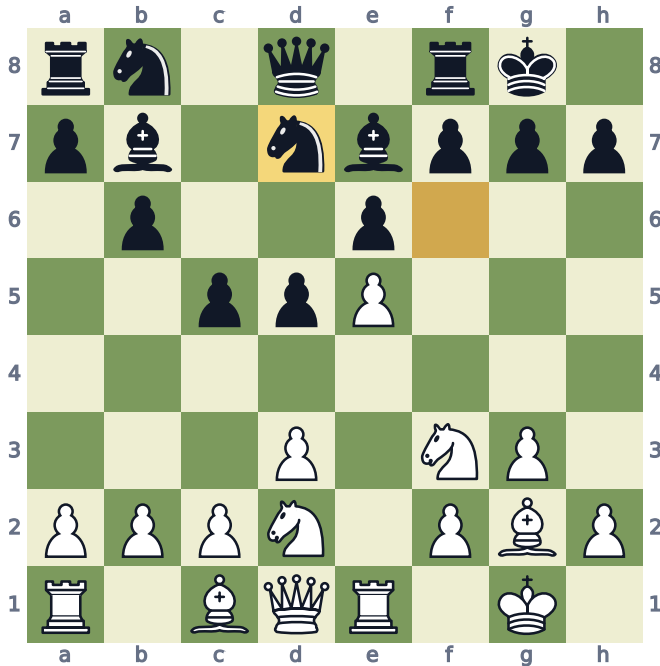
RULE | Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. e5 Nfd7



- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.
- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nfd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When ...c5 joins ...Bb7, Black attacks d4 and e4 from two directions; White's e5 gains space but must survive undermining pressure.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses the knight retreat tempo to improve the attack and watches whether c3 is needed to restrain ...d4. The line fails as a template when: Assuming the bishop is dead after e5 while Black has a direct pawn break to release it.

STORE THIS | Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

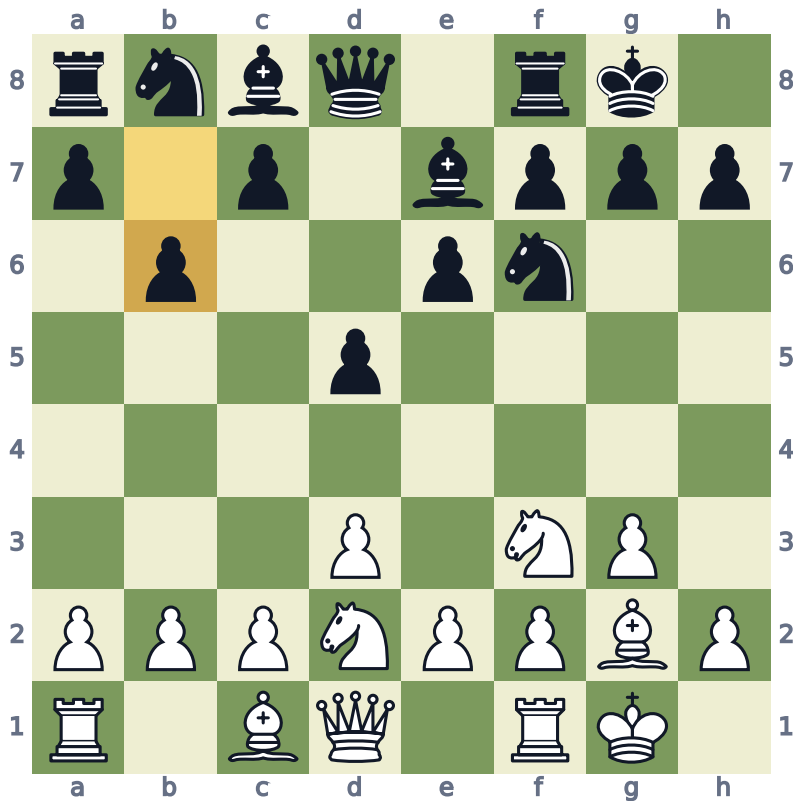
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. e5 Nfd7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: White's c3 restraint



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8.

DECISION RULE

What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black completes development and challenges the center before White's slow kingside routes become active.

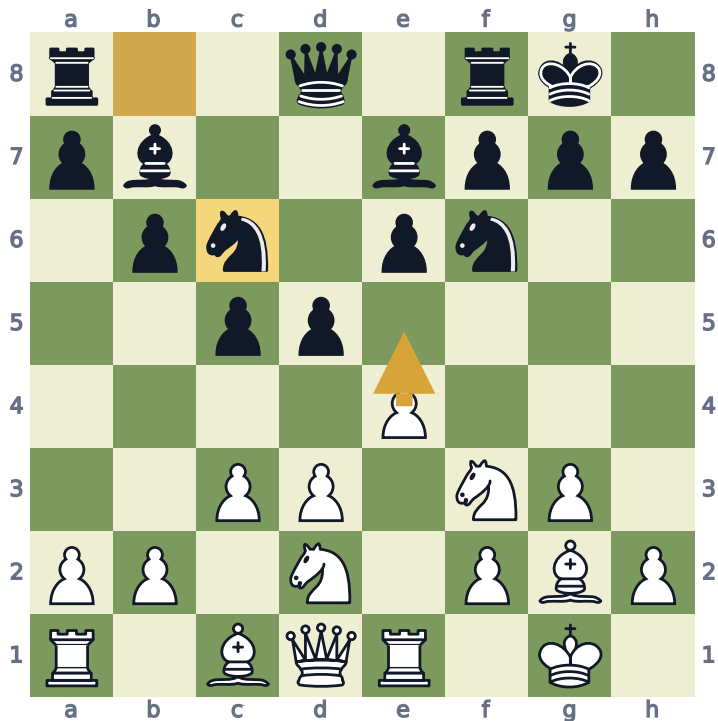
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move.

MEMORY RULE | A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black completes development and challenges the center before White's slow kingside routes become active.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move.

FAILURE MODE

Playing c3 defensively and then leaving the center unchanged while Black improves every piece.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

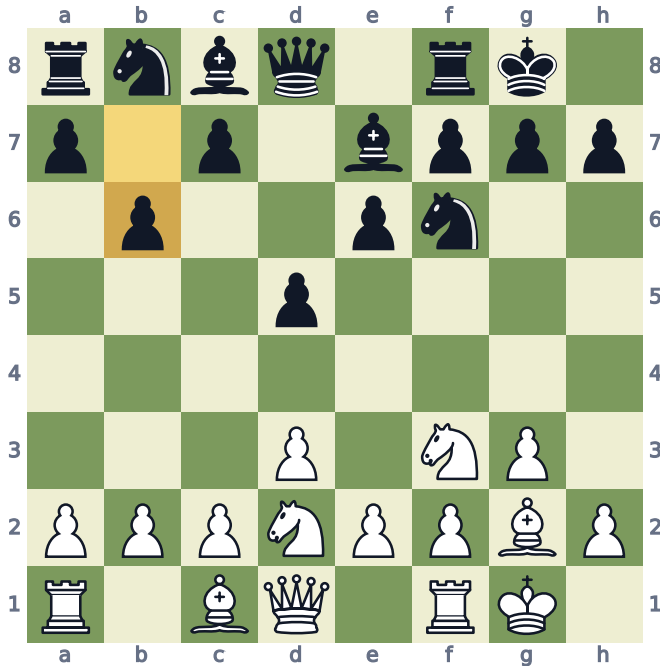
RULE | A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. c3 Nc6



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move. The line fails as a template when: Playing c3 defensively and then leaving the center unchanged while Black improves every piece.

STORE THIS | A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

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ANSWER KEY

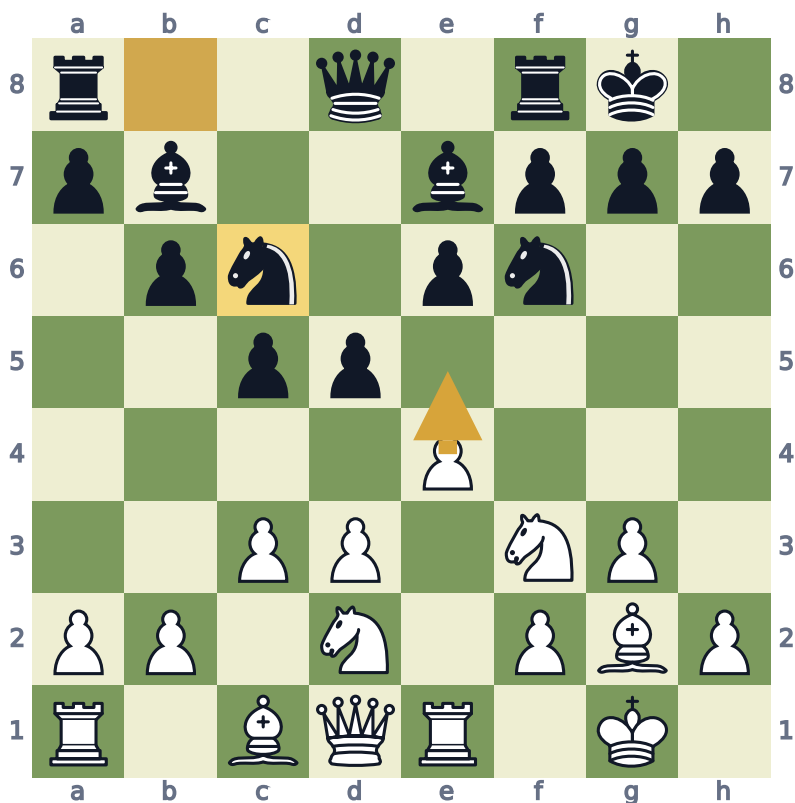
1. c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8. 2. Black completes development and challenges the center before White's slow kingside routes become active. 3. White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move. 4. What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo? 5. Playing c3 defensively and then leaving the center unchanged while Black improves every piece.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: White's c3 restraint



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8.

DECISION RULE

What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black completes development and challenges the center before White's slow kingside routes become active.

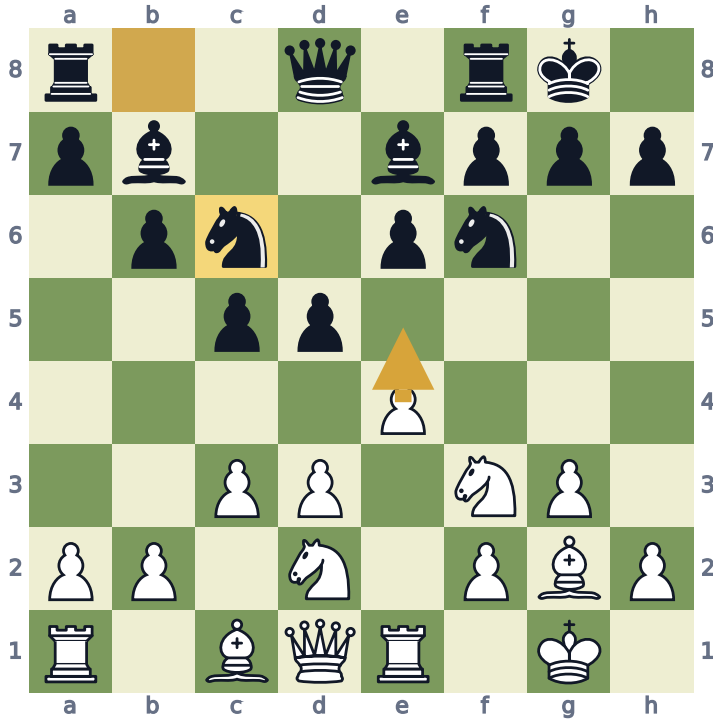
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move.

MEMORY RULE | A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black completes development and challenges the center before White's slow kingside routes become active.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move.

FAILURE MODE

Playing c3 defensively and then leaving the center unchanged while Black improves every piece.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

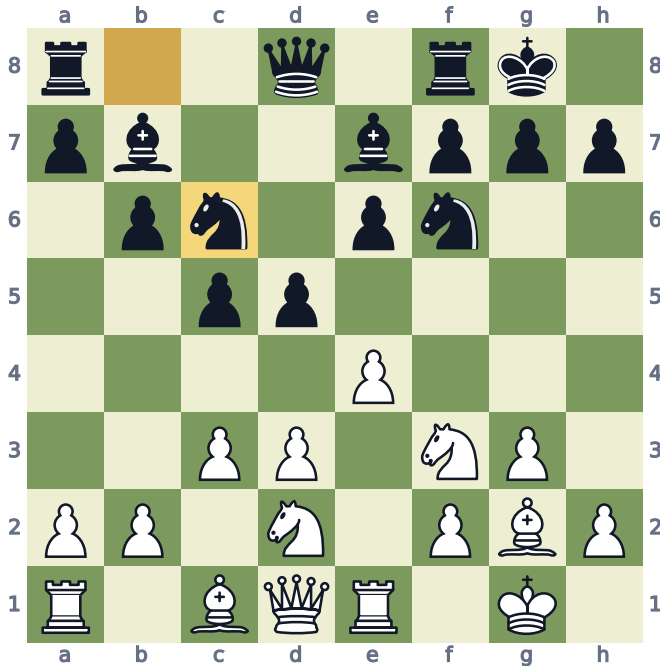
RULE | A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. c3 Nc6



- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.
- c3: White restrains d4 and prepares a central d4 break.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move. The line fails as a template when: Playing c3 defensively and then leaving the center unchanged while Black improves every piece.

STORE THIS | A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. c3 supports e4 and restrains ...d4, but it spends a tempo, blocks the knight's natural square, and may invite ...Qc7 or ...Rd8. 2. Black completes development and challenges the center before White's slow kingside routes become active. 3. White uses c3 as a functional restraint, then follows with e5, Qe2, or d4 rather than treating it as another shell move. 4. What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo? 5. Playing c3 defensively and then leaving the center unchanged while Black improves every piece.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. c3 Nc6

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 067 Decode: Black fianchettos on b7

Prompt: How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed?

Recall: Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

LESSON 068 Play: Black fianchettos on b7

Prompt: How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed?

Recall: Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

LESSON 069 Decode: The ...c5 central challenge

Prompt: Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4?

Recall: Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

LESSON 070 Play: The ...c5 central challenge

Prompt: Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4?

Recall: Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

LESSON 071 Decode: White's c3 restraint

Prompt: What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo?

Recall: A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

LESSON 072 Play: White's c3 restraint

Prompt: What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo?

Recall: A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Black fianchettoes on b7

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5

Decision: How many real defenders protect e4 after each exchange, and is the b7 bishop pinned or unobstructed?

Memory: Against ...Bb7, count the e4 pawn's legal defenders before beginning the attack.

CARD 2

The ...c5 central challenge

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. e5 Nfd7

Decision: Does e5 close the b7 bishop effectively, and can Black reopen it with ...f6 or ...d4?

Memory: Close a diagonal only if you can delay the break that reopens it.

CARD 3

White's c3 restraint

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 b6 7. e4 Bb7 8. Re1 c5 9. c3 Nc6

Decision: What specific ...d4 or ...dxe4 tactic does c3 prevent, and what active follow-up justifies the tempo?

Memory: A restraining move must buy time for an active follow-up.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
067 Decode: Black fianchettoes on b7	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
068 Play: Black fianchettoes on b7	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
069 Decode: The ...c5 central challenge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
070 Play: The ...c5 central challenge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
071 Decode: White's c3 restraint	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
072 Play: White's c3 restraint	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.